Warm-up / A more successful reading club

What does 'better' actually mean?

Name: _____ Date: _____

Suggested lesson time: 30 minutes. Work individually, then compare when invited.

Useful words

Ambiguous term: A word or phrase with more than one reasonable meaning in its context.

Measure: An observable quantity used to judge a particular feature, such as weekly interruptions or average test scores.

Comparison period: The times being compared, such as the four weeks before and after a rule.

Read the scenario

Invented scenario: A club leader says, 'Our reading club became more successful this month.' Average attendance per meeting rose from 12 last month to 18 this month, but the average number of books finished per member stayed at one per month.

Produce: Write one ambiguous phrase, two possible meanings, and the result under each meaning.

Your steps

1. Identify the phrase that needs a clearer meaning.
2. Give one meaning using attendance and one using books finished per member.
3. State whether each meaning shows improvement in this month compared with last month.

Before you finish: Do your two meanings refer to different outcomes, and does each conclusion match the figures?

Your response

Main activity / Does the phone rule make lessons better?

Name: _____

Read the scenario

Invented scenario: A principal says a new phone rule makes lessons 'better'. In the same ten classes, weekly phone interruptions fell from 20 to 12, but average test scores stayed at 70 out of 100. Both figures compare the four weeks before the rule with the four weeks after it.

Produce: Write two definitions, two conclusions applying those definitions, and one sentence explaining how to choose a measure.

Your steps

1. Write two possible definitions of 'better': one using interruptions and one using test scores. For each, state the direction of improvement, the group, and the comparison period.
2. Apply each definition to the supplied figures and say whether it shows an improvement.
3. Finish with one sentence explaining why the school's purpose should guide its choice of measure before results are inspected.

Before you finish: Could a reader apply your two rules to the figures without guessing? Separate observing a change from claiming the rule caused it.

Your response

Exit ticket / A better bus service?

Name: _____

Read the scenario

Invented scenario: A town calls its revised bus service 'better'. On the same route, average passenger waiting time fell from 12 minutes in the month before the revision to 8 minutes in the month after it. The fare per journey rose from $2 to $3 over the same comparison. No other outcomes are supplied.

Produce: Write two clear definitions of 'better', apply each to the figures, and write one sentence about choosing between them.

Your steps

1. Define 'better' using waiting time, naming the direction of improvement, route, and periods.
2. Define 'better' using fare per journey, again naming the direction of improvement and comparison.
3. State what each definition shows and why the town should identify its priority before selecting a definition.

Before you finish: Have you distinguished an improvement in waiting time from a worsening in affordability, without claiming either captures every aspect of the service?

Your response